Pennsylvania Native Creatures

Choose one. Learn its story. Lead it into the green pasture.

Mammals

White-tailed Deer
American Black Bear
North American River Otter
Indiana Bat
Northern Long-eared Bat
Allegheny Woodrat
Northern Flying Squirrel
Snowshoe Hare
Bobcat
Fisher
Elk

Reptiles & Amphibians

Eastern Hellbender
Bog Turtle
Eastern Box Turtle
Wood Turtle
Timber Rattlesnake
Eastern Massasauga
Spotted Salamander
Wood Frog
Eastern Newt
Spring Peeper

Trees & Plants

Eastern Hemlock
Mountain Laurel
American Chestnut
White Oak
Sugar Maple
Common Milkweed
Cardinal Flower
Jack-in-the-Pulpit
Great White Trillium
Swamp Pink
Pawpaw
Pink Lady's Slipper
Black-eyed Susan
Eastern White Pine

Birds

Ruffed Grouse
Bald Eagle
Peregrine Falcon
Piping Plover
Golden-winged Warbler
Cerulean Warbler
Wood Thrush
Great Blue Heron
Eastern Bluebird
Barn Owl
Osprey
Ruby-throated Hummingbird
Pileated Woodpecker
Wild Turkey

Fish & River Life

Brook Trout
American Shad
Lake Sturgeon
American Eel
Northern Riffleshell Mussel

Insects

Pennsylvania Firefly
Monarch Butterfly
Rusty Patched Bumble Bee
Regal Fritillary
Luna Moth
Eastern Tiger Swallowtail

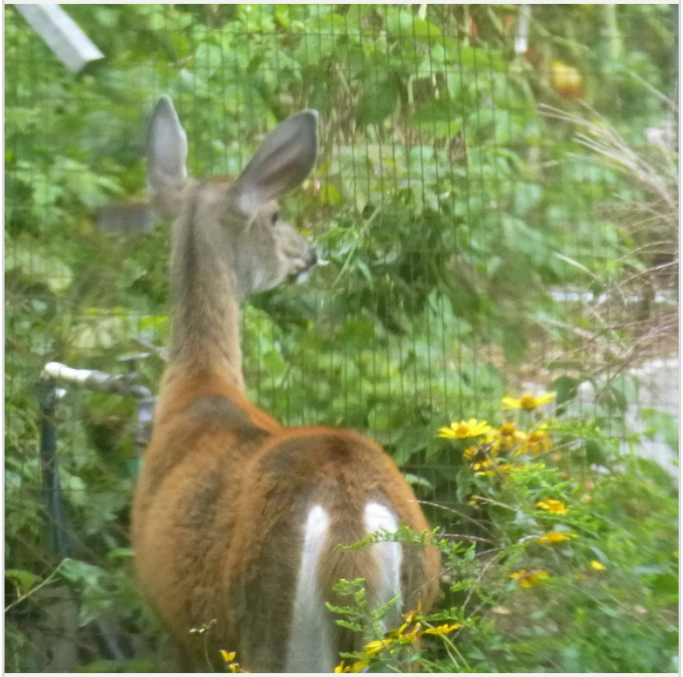
Red = endangered, threatened, or disappearing
Orange = hurt by the changing climate
Green = brought back from the brink

Photos by iNaturalist community members, shared under Creative Commons licenses (credited on each page). Facts written for kids.

White-tailed Deer

Odocoileus virginianus

Pennsylvania's state animal



Up close · photo: Ira Gershenhorn (iNaturalist, CC0)

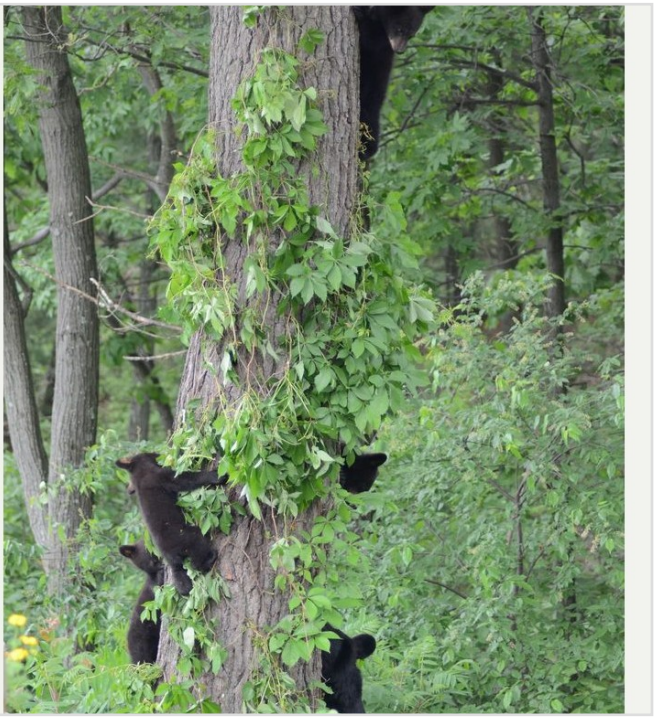
Whole creature · photo: Denise Christopher (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

A fawn is born with white spots and almost no scent, so it can hide in tall grass while its mother feeds nearby. Male deer grow a brand-new set of antlers every year and drop them each winter.

American Black Bear

Ursus americanus

Doing well



Up close · photo: bernicez (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: joeverica (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Pennsylvania's black bears are some of the biggest in the world, and a few have weighed more than 800 pounds. In winter they sleep in dens for months without eating or drinking, and cubs are born while the mother is still dozing.

North American River Otter

Lontra canadensis

Brought back from the brink

Up close · photo: mikeintyler (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: SJDipper (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Otters nearly vanished from Pennsylvania because of dirty water, but people cleaned up the rivers and released otters back in the 1980s and 90s, and now they live in rivers across the state. They can hold their breath for several minutes and love to slide down muddy banks on their bellies.

Indiana Bat

Myotis sodalis

Endangered

Up close · photo: Marlo Perdicas (iNaturalist, CC-BY)

Whole creature · photo: steelbirder (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

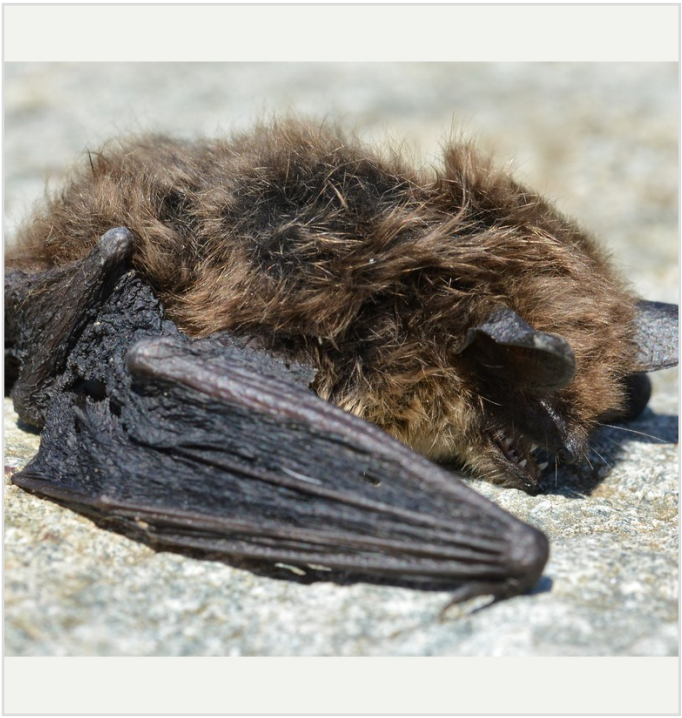
This tiny bat weighs less than three pennies and can eat half its weight in insects in a single night. A disease called white-nose syndrome, which attacks bats while they sleep in caves all winter, has wiped out most of Pennsylvania's Indiana bats, so they need our help.

Northern Long-eared Bat

Myotis septentrionalis

Endangered

Up close · photo: Marlo Perdicas (iNaturalist, CC-BY)



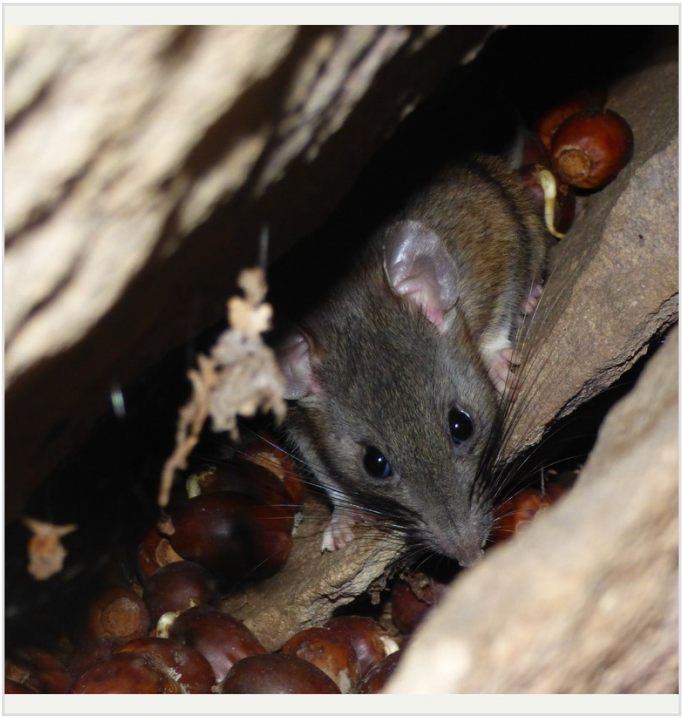
Whole creature · photo: Ryan Hodnett (iNaturalist, CC-BY-SA)

Its long ears help it find moths hiding on leaves, which it plucks right off the plant. White-nose syndrome has killed more than nine out of every ten northern long-eared bats in Pennsylvania.

Allegheny Woodrat

Neotoma magister

Threatened in Pennsylvania



Up close · photo: Gavin (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: jsellis (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

This gentle, big-eyed rat lives on rocky cliffs and collects shiny things like bottle caps and bones to store in its nest. Its numbers are falling because forests are being chopped into smaller pieces and a parasite carried by raccoons makes it sick.

Northern Flying Squirrel

Glaucomys sabrinus

Endangered in Pennsylvania · climate-sensitive

Up close · photo: kathleenfspicer (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: bcnorval (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

It doesn't really fly; it glides from tree to tree on a flap of skin stretched between its legs, sometimes more than 100 feet in one leap. It needs cold, old hemlock and spruce forests, and as Pennsylvania warms, those forests are shrinking.

Snowshoe Hare

Lepus americanus

Climate-sensitive

Up close · photo: Russ Hoverman (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Jonathan Gagnon (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Its fur turns white every winter so it can hide in the snow, and brown again in summer. With less snow falling in Pennsylvania's winters, a white hare on brown ground is easy for predators to spot.

Bobcat

Lynx rufus

Doing well

Up close · photo: Nancy (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: tara-baesmat (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Pennsylvania's only wild cat is about twice the size of a house cat, with tufted ears and a short 'bobbed' tail. Bobcats are so quiet and shy that most people never see one, even though they live across most of the state.

Fisher

Pekania pennanti

Brought back from the brink

Up close · photo: Rob Curtis (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-SA)

Whole creature · photo: Brian Schmoke (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Fishers are one of the few animals brave enough to hunt porcupines. They disappeared from Pennsylvania over a century ago when the forests were cut down, but were brought back in the 1990s and are now spreading across the state.

Elk

Cervus canadensis

Brought back from the brink

Up close · photo: John Boback (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

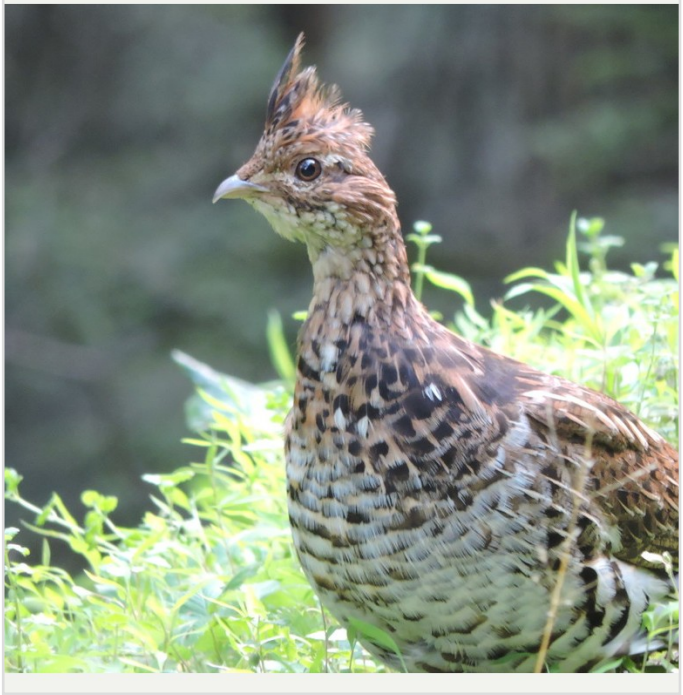
Whole creature · photo: slearac17 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Elk once roamed all of Pennsylvania but were wiped out by the 1870s; a small herd was brought from Yellowstone starting in 1913, and today about 1,400 elk live in the mountains of north-central Pennsylvania. In fall, bull elk make a loud whistling call called a bugle that can be heard for miles.

Ruffed Grouse

Bonasa umbellus

Pennsylvania's state bird · declining



Up close · photo: D.J. McNeil (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: D.J. McNeil (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

In spring the male stands on a log and beats his wings so fast it sounds like a drum starting up. Pennsylvania's state bird is disappearing from much of the state because of West Nile virus and the loss of young, brushy forests.

Bald Eagle

Haliaeetus leucocephalus

Brought back from the brink

Up close · photo: nfitzhugh (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: hallm (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

In 1983 only three pairs of bald eagles nested in all of Pennsylvania, poisoned by a pesticide called DDT; after the pesticide was banned and young eagles were brought in from Canada, there are now more than 300 nests. An eagle nest can be as wide as a car and weigh a ton.

Peregrine Falcon

Falco peregrinus

Brought back from the brink

Up close · photo: pacificnorthwestkate (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Travis Suckow (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

The fastest animal on Earth, a peregrine can dive at more than 200 miles per hour to catch birds in midair. They vanished from Pennsylvania's cliffs in the 1960s, but now nest on bridges and skyscrapers in Pittsburgh, Harrisburg, and Philadelphia.

Piping Plover

Charadrius melodus

Endangered

Up close · photo: Victor W Fazio III (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-ND)

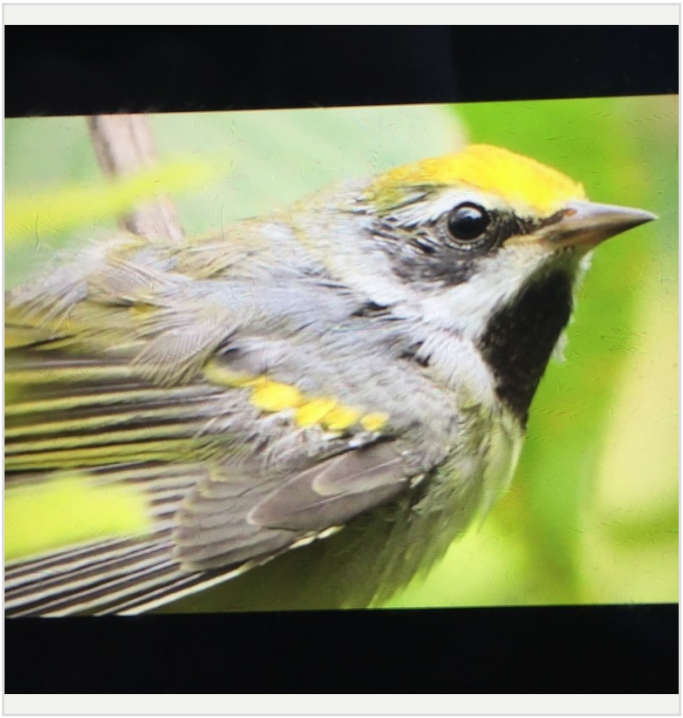
Whole creature · photo: lucyj1 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

This sand-colored shorebird is so well camouflaged that it seems to vanish when it stands still on the beach. Piping plovers hadn't nested in Pennsylvania for over 60 years until a pair returned to Presque Isle on Lake Erie in 2017.

Golden-winged Warbler

Vermivora chrysoptera

Declining



Up close · photo: D.J. McNeil (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: D.J. McNeil (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

This little yellow-capped songbird flies all the way to Central and South America every winter and back to Pennsylvania every spring. It needs young, shrubby forests to nest in, and as those grow up into tall woods, the warbler is losing its home.

Cerulean Warbler

Setophaga cerulea

Declining

Up close · photo: psweet (iNaturalist, CC-BY-SA)

Whole creature · photo: holgerp (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

The male is the color of a clear summer sky, and he sings from the very tops of the tallest trees, so he is heard far more often than seen. It is one of the fastest-declining songbirds in America, and Pennsylvania's big forests are one of its most important homes.

Wood Thrush

Hylocichla mustelina

Declining

Up close · photo: Jenn (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-SA)

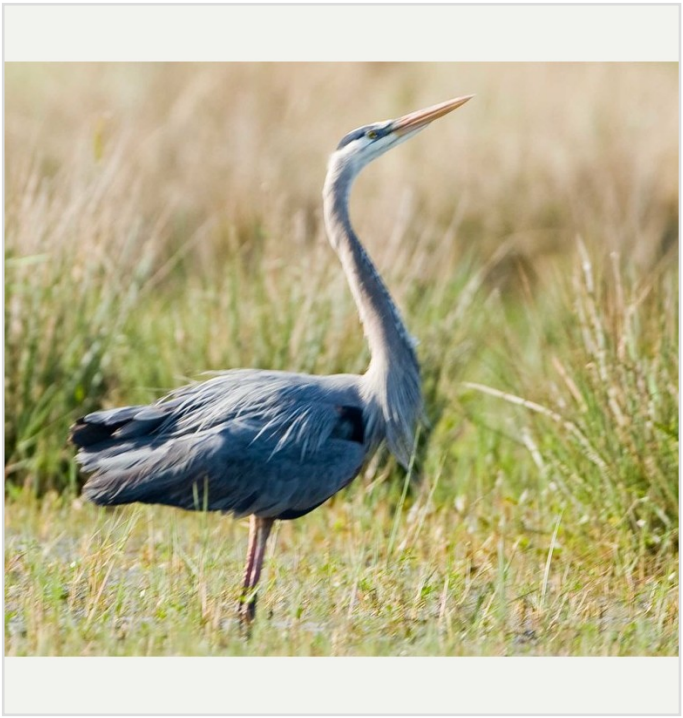
Whole creature · photo: sgreene13 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Its flute-like evening song is one of the most beautiful sounds in a Pennsylvania forest, and it can actually sing two notes at once. Wood thrushes have lost more than half their numbers since the 1960s as forests shrink here and in Central America.

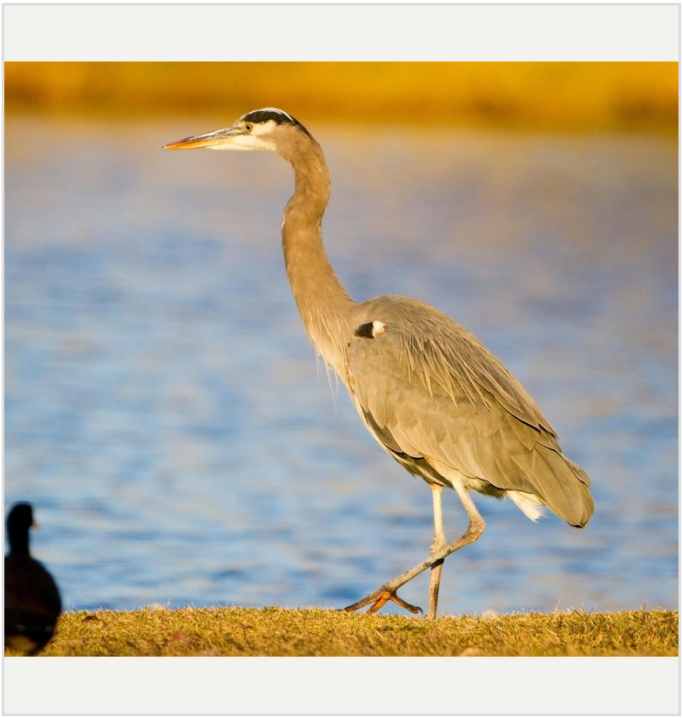
Great Blue Heron

Ardea herodias

Doing well



Up close · photo: BJ Stacey (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)



Whole creature · photo: BJ Stacey (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Standing four feet tall, this patient bird can freeze like a statue for minutes, then strike a fish with its spear-shaped bill faster than you can blink. Herons nest together high in trees in big groups called rookeries, sometimes dozens of nests in one spot.

Eastern Bluebird

Sialia sialis

Brought back from the brink

Up close · photo: jbh1992 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: alyssa71504 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Bluebirds almost disappeared when the old wooden fence posts they nested in were replaced and house sparrows took over their holes. People across Pennsylvania built thousands of bluebird boxes, and the bluebirds came back.

Barn Owl

Tyto alba

Rare in Pennsylvania

Up close · photo: Rolando Pasos Pérez (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Sergio Picó (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

A barn owl's heart-shaped face works like a satellite dish, catching sounds so well it can catch a mouse in total darkness. It needs old barns and open meadows to live, and as those disappear, barn owls have become rare in Pennsylvania.

Osprey

Pandion haliaetus

Brought back from the brink

Up close · photo: Joseph Salmieri Jr. (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Maria Andreina Pacheco (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

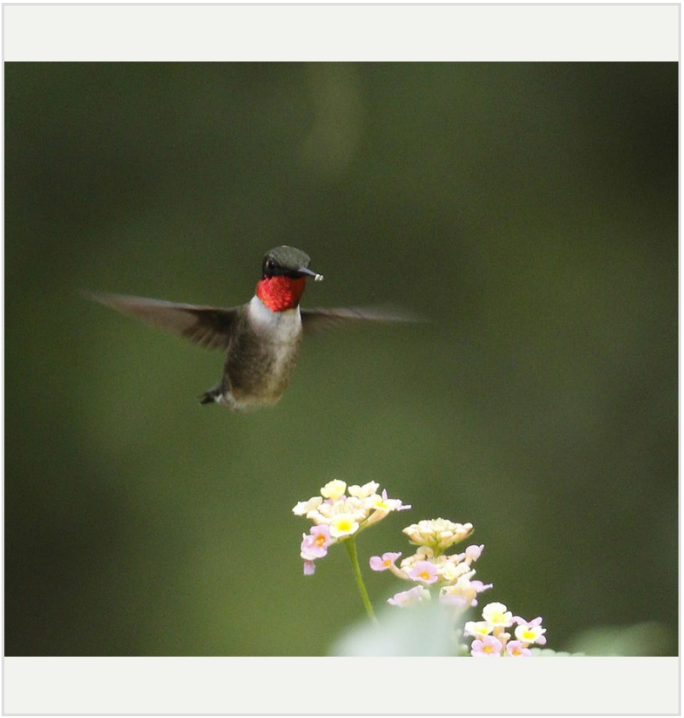
Ospreys eat almost nothing but fish, diving feet-first into the water and carrying their catch headfirst like a torpedo. Wiped out in Pennsylvania by pesticides, they were brought back by raising chicks on platforms, and came off the state's threatened list in 2017.

Ruby-throated Hummingbird

Archilochus colubris

Doing well

Up close · photo: Andrew Mack (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)



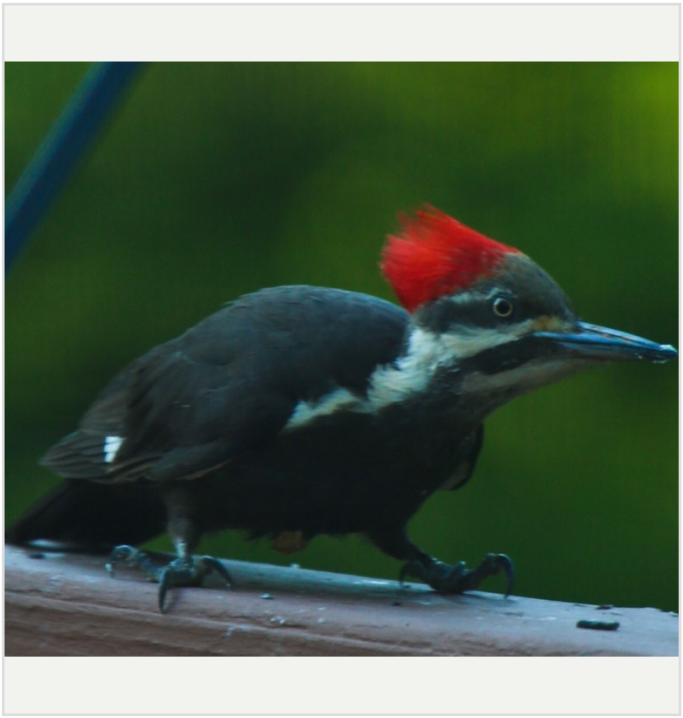
Whole creature · photo: Donna Pomeroy (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

This bird weighs about as much as a penny, yet it flies nonstop across the Gulf of Mexico, 500 miles, on its way to its winter home. Its wings beat more than 50 times every second, and it is the only hummingbird that nests in Pennsylvania.

Pileated Woodpecker

Dryocopus pileatus

Doing well



Up close · photo: drswamp (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: nwinograd (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

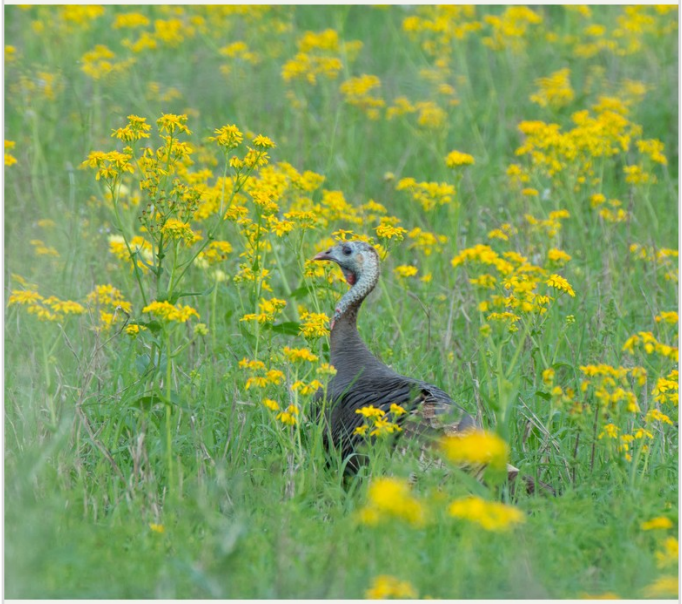
As big as a crow with a flaming red crest, this woodpecker chisels rectangular holes into dead trees to find carpenter ants. The holes it leaves behind become homes for owls, ducks, bats, and flying squirrels.

Wild Turkey

Meleagris gallopavo

Brought back from the brink

Up close · photo: twsummer (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)



Whole creature · photo: Roger Shaw (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-SA)

Wild turkeys were almost gone from Pennsylvania 100 years ago, but careful protection helped them come back to every county. They can run 25 miles per hour, fly in short bursts up to 55, and they sleep in trees at night.

Eastern Hellbender

Cryptobranchus alleganiensis

Pennsylvania's state amphibian · declining

Up close · photo: D.J. McNeil (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Brian Gratwicke (iNaturalist, CC-BY)

North America's biggest salamander can grow longer than a skateboard and breathes through the wrinkly folds of its skin. It needs cold, clean, rocky streams, so when mud and pollution wash in, hellbenders disappear; Pennsylvania students helped make it the state amphibian in 2019 to protect it.

Bog Turtle

Glyptemys muhlenbergii

Endangered

Up close · photo: groverbrown (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: snakeinmypocket (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

America's smallest turtle is only about four inches long and has a bright orange patch on each side of its neck. It lives in spring-fed, soggy meadows that are being drained and built over, so bog turtles are now among the rarest turtles in the country.

Eastern Box Turtle

Terrapene carolina

Declining

Up close · photo: Tracee (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

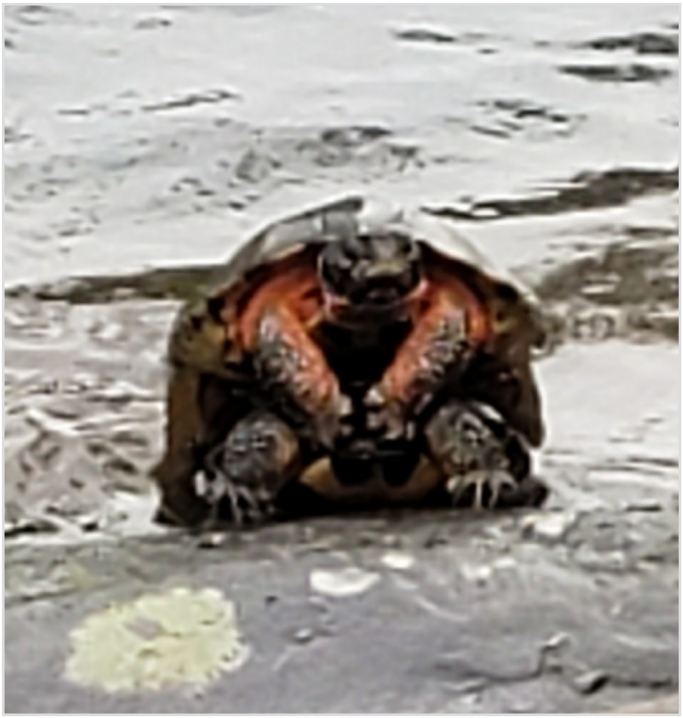
Whole creature · photo: Megan Jordan (iNaturalist, CC-BY)

A box turtle can close its hinged shell so tightly that not even a knife blade can slip in. Box turtles can live more than 100 years, and many spend their whole life within a few acres of where they hatched.

Wood Turtle

Glyptemys insculpta

Declining



Up close · photo: Anna (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: J.D. Willson (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Wood turtles stomp on the ground with their feet to trick earthworms into coming up, then eat them. They are being lost from Pennsylvania's streams because of roads, farming, and people taking them home as pets.

Timber Rattlesnake

Crotalus horridus

Protected in Pennsylvania

Up close · photo: Nicholas Pollock (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Jeff Polonoli (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Timber rattlesnakes are shy and would much rather hide than bite; the rattle is a warning that says 'please go away.' A mother gives birth to live babies and stays with them for about a week, and the snakes return to the same rocky dens every winter for their whole lives.

Eastern Massasauga

Sistrurus catenatus

Endangered in Pennsylvania

Up close · photo: Jay Fitzsimmons (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Bruce Edmunds (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

This small, gentle rattlesnake lives in wet meadows in just a few places in western Pennsylvania. Its name comes from an Ojibwe word meaning 'great river-mouth,' and it is one of the rarest animals in the state.

Spotted Salamander

Ambystoma maculatum

Doing well

Up close · photo: salamanderdance (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Joe Franckiewicz (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

On the first warm, rainy night of spring, hundreds of spotted salamanders crawl out from underground to the same pond where they were born to lay their eggs. Their eggs have tiny green algae living inside them, which give the babies oxygen.

Wood Frog

Lithobates sylvaticus

Doing well

Up close · photo: rascal16 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Ty Sharrow (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-SA)

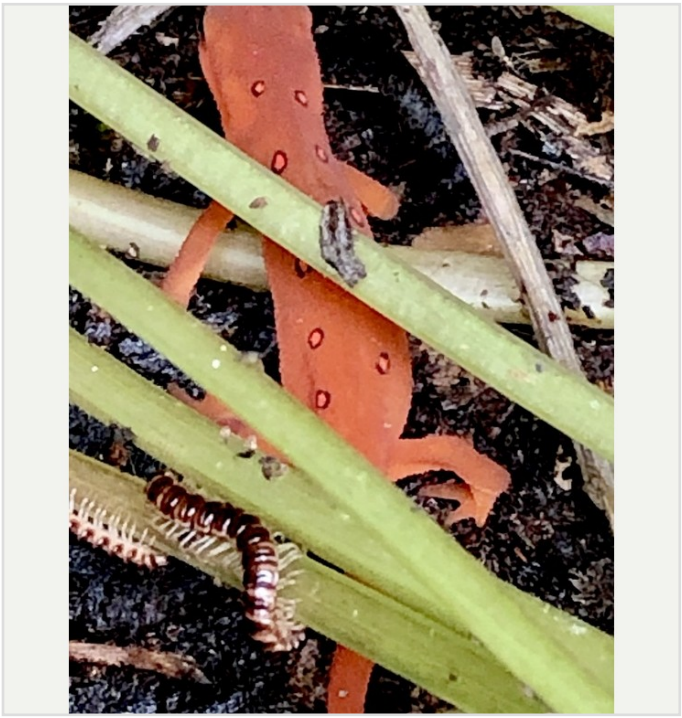
In winter, a wood frog freezes nearly solid; its heart stops and it doesn't breathe, then it thaws out alive in spring. It wears a dark robber's mask across its eyes, and its call sounds like a quacking duck.

Eastern Newt

Notophthalmus viridescens

Doing well

Up close · photo: keithleonar (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)



Whole creature · photo: octobertraveler (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

A young newt is called a red eft, a bright orange creature that walks the forest floor for years before going back to the water and turning green. Its bright color warns predators that its skin is poisonous.

Spring Peeper

Pseudacris crucifer

Doing well

Up close · photo: appalachianmushroom (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: stephaniezed (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

This frog is smaller than a paper clip, but on a spring night a chorus of peepers can be heard more than a mile away. Each one has a dark X on its back, which is how it got its Latin name crucifer, 'cross-bearer.'

Brook Trout

Salvelinus fontinalis

Pennsylvania's state fish · climate-sensitive

Up close · photo: drcrawdad (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: morgzwi (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Pennsylvania's only native trout has a dark green back with worm-like squiggles and bright red spots ringed in blue. It can only live in cold, clean water, so as streams warm with the changing climate, brook trout are being squeezed into smaller and smaller spaces.

American Shad

Alosa sapidissima

Recovering

Up close · photo: Claude Nozères (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: pmk00001 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Shad are born in rivers, swim out to the ocean for years, and then find their way back to the very river where they hatched to lay their eggs. Dams blocked them from Pennsylvania's rivers for over a century, but fish ladders and dam removals are slowly opening the way home.

Lake Sturgeon

Acipenser fulvescens

Endangered in Pennsylvania

Up close · photo: Bradley Rasmussen (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: St.LawrenceRiverInstitute ofEnvirironmentalSciences

A lake sturgeon is a living dinosaur with rows of bony plates instead of scales; it can grow seven feet long and live more than 100 years. It was almost fished out of Lake Erie, and today it is endangered in Pennsylvania.

American Eel

Anguilla rostrata

Declining

Up close · photo: volt77 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: sethdangle (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Every American eel is born in the Sargasso Sea near Bermuda, and the tiny babies drift for a year to reach rivers like the Susquehanna. After living in fresh water for ten or twenty years, they swim all the way back to the ocean to lay their eggs.

Northern Riffleshell Mussel

Epioblasma rangiana

Endangered

Up close · photo: Philippe Blais (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-ND)

Whole creature · photo: Philippe Blais (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-ND)

This freshwater mussel lures fish with a flap that looks like a tiny minnow, then sprays its babies onto the fish's gills to hitch a ride upstream. Nearly wiped out by pollution and dams, most of the world's remaining riffleshells live in the Allegheny River and French Creek in Pennsylvania.

Pennsylvania Firefly

Photuris pensylvanica

Pennsylvania's state insect

Up close · photo: Louis Imbeau (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: sarac (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Fireflies make light inside their bodies with a chemical reaction that gives off almost no heat, more efficient than any light bulb. Each kind of firefly flashes its own secret code, and bright lights from houses and streets make it hard for them to find each other.

Monarch Butterfly

Danaus plexippus

Declining

Up close · photo: roamingthewoods (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

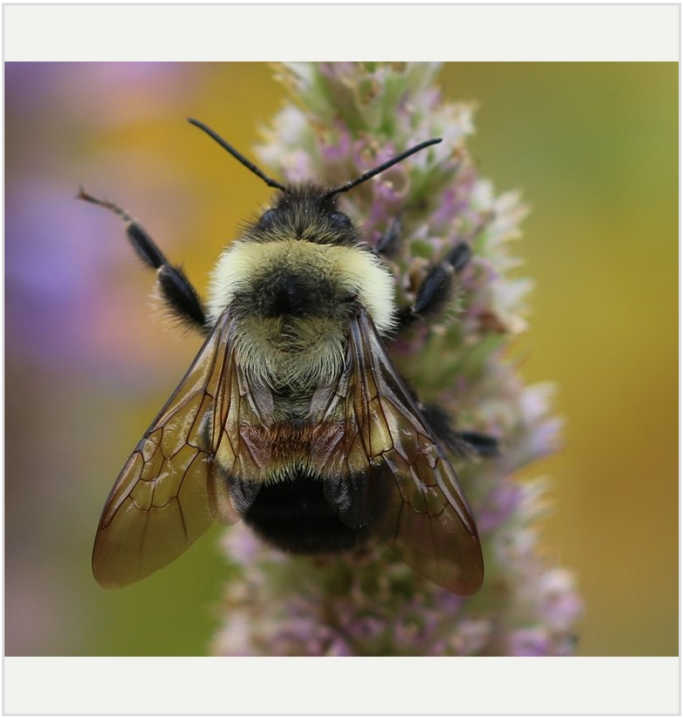
Whole creature · photo: roamingthewoods (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

A monarch born in Pennsylvania in late summer flies almost 3,000 miles to spend the winter in mountain forests in Mexico, a place it has never seen. Monarch caterpillars eat only milkweed, so planting milkweed is one of the best ways to help them.

Rusty Patched Bumble Bee

Bombus affinis

Endangered



Up close · photo: Alex Harman (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: kimcwren (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

This fuzzy bee was once common across Pennsylvania, but it has almost completely disappeared, and in 2017 it became the first bumble bee ever placed on the endangered species list. It buzz-pollinates by grabbing a flower and vibrating its wings to shake the pollen loose.

Regal Fritillary

Argynnis idalia

Rare

Up close · photo: Jeff Skrentny (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole creature · photo: Alex Harman (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

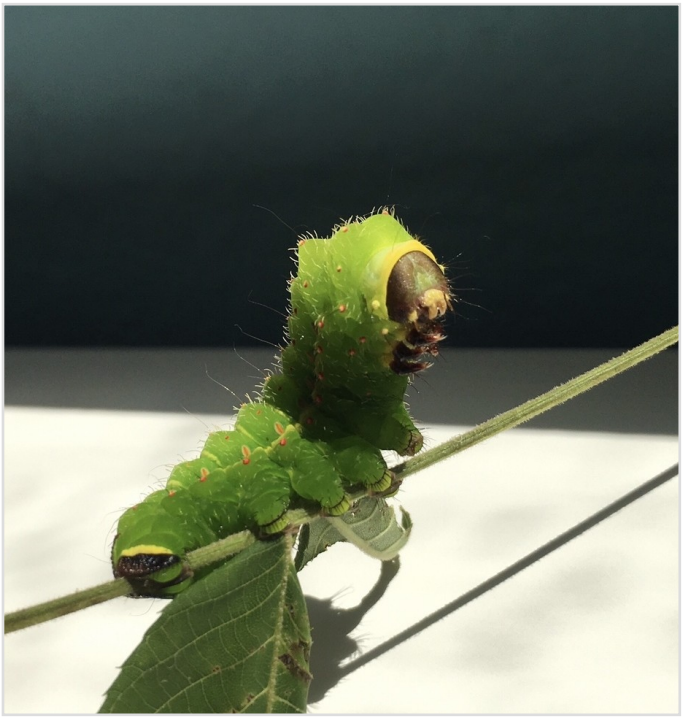
This big orange-and-black butterfly has vanished from nearly all of the eastern United States, and its last home east of the Mississippi is a military training ground in Pennsylvania called Fort Indiantown Gap. Its caterpillars eat only violets, so it needs open meadows full of them.

Luna Moth

Actias luna

Doing well

Up close · photo: Holly Merker (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)



Whole creature · photo: bubblecat (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

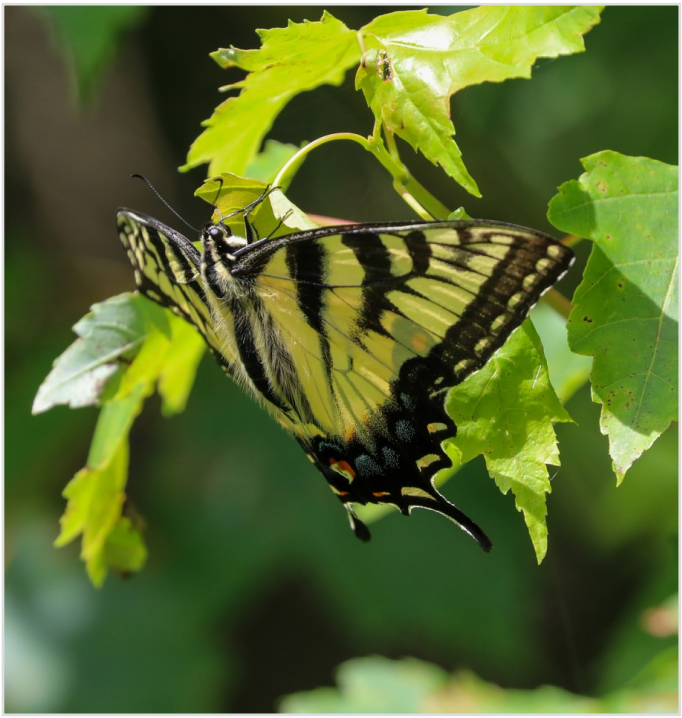
This pale green moth is as big as your hand, with long tails that spin in flight to confuse the bats that hunt it. Adults have no mouth and never eat; they live only about a week, just long enough to find a mate.

Eastern Tiger Swallowtail

Papilio glaucus

Doing well

Up close · photo: adjr (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)



Whole creature · photo: cameala (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-ND)

Pennsylvania's biggest common butterfly has yellow wings with tiger stripes, and some females are nearly all black to look like the poisonous pipevine swallowtail. Its caterpillar has two big fake eyespots that make it look like a tiny snake.

Eastern Hemlock

Tsuga canadensis

Pennsylvania's state tree · threatened by an invasive insect

Up close · photo: Alexander Kraut (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: Michael Blacketter (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Pennsylvania's state tree can live more than 500 years, and its deep shade keeps streams cold for brook trout. A tiny insect from Asia called the hemlock woolly adelgid, which looks like bits of cotton on the needles, is killing hemlocks across the state.

Mountain Laurel

Kalmia latifolia

Pennsylvania's state flower

Up close · photo: arrowmen2016 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: chlorophyll-a (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

In June, Pennsylvania's mountainsides turn pink and white when the state flower blooms. Each flower has ten tiny spring-loaded stamens that snap forward and dust visiting bees with pollen.

American Chestnut

Castanea dentata

Nearly gone

Up close · photo: John Boback (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: caroltraveny_57 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

A hundred years ago, one out of every four trees in Pennsylvania's forests was a towering American chestnut, feeding bears, turkeys, and people with its sweet nuts. A fungus from overseas killed nearly every one, but scientists are working to breed chestnuts that can survive.

White Oak

Quercus alba

Doing well

Up close · photo: bryofighter (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: Sara Rall (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

A single white oak can live 300 years and feed more than 500 kinds of caterpillars, plus the deer, turkeys, squirrels, and blue jays that eat its acorns. Native people and early settlers ground the acorns into flour.

Sugar Maple

Acer saccharum

Climate-sensitive

Up close · photo: Mike Leveille (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: Marv Elliott (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

It takes about 40 gallons of sugar maple sap, boiled down, to make one gallon of maple syrup. Sap runs only when nights freeze and days thaw, so as winters warm, Pennsylvania's maple-syrup season is growing shorter.

Common Milkweed

Asclepias syriaca

Doing well

Up close · photo: mwalke4 (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: Jane Auty Kirkland (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-ND)

Milkweed is the only plant monarch caterpillars can eat, and its milky sap makes them poisonous to birds. In fall its pods split open and send hundreds of seeds floating away on silky parachutes.

Cardinal Flower

Lobelia cardinalis

Doing well

Up close · photo: barbaraelmer (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: Andrea Kautz (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Its flowers are the brightest red in Pennsylvania's wetlands, shaped just right for a hummingbird's beak. Most bees can't reach the nectar, so cardinal flower depends almost entirely on hummingbirds to spread its pollen.

Jack-in-the-Pulpit

Arisaema triphyllum

Doing well

Up close · photo: Beatrice (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: Nur Ritter (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

'Jack' is the little spike standing inside a striped green hood that looks like an old-fashioned church pulpit. The same plant can be male one year and female the next, depending on how much food it has stored in its root.

Great White Trillium

Trillium grandiflorum

Doing well

Up close · photo: yurick (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

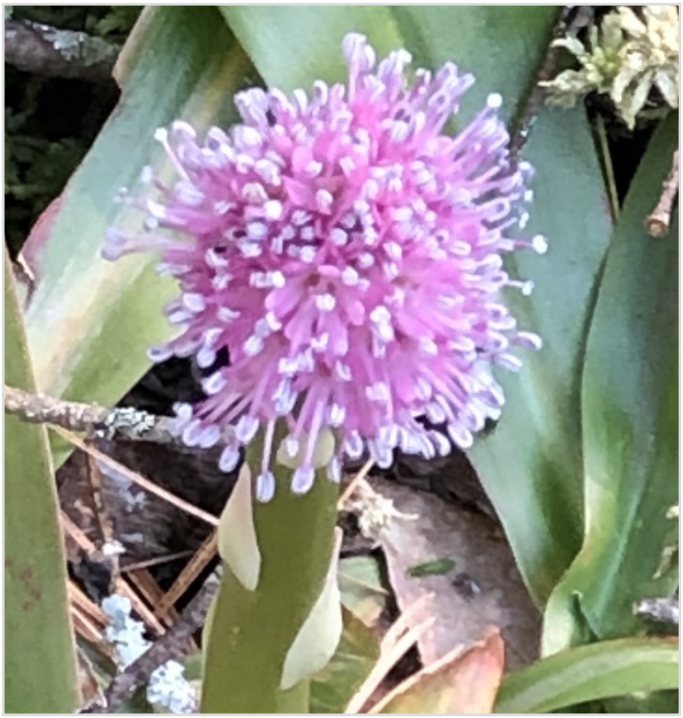
Whole plant · photo: John Boback (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Everything about trillium comes in threes: three leaves, three petals, three sepals. Its seeds are carried off and planted by ants, and it can take seven years for a seed to become a blooming plant.

Swamp Pink

Helonias bullata

Threatened



Up close · photo: jamesonjc (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: linkmdavis (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

This rare wetland flower sends up a single stalk topped with a pink pom-pom that smells faintly sweet. It grows only in a few swampy spots in Pennsylvania and nearby states, and it is protected by law.

Pawpaw

Asimina triloba

Doing well

Up close · photo: mhcagan (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: Tanya Sulikowski (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Pawpaw is the largest fruit native to North America, and it tastes like a mix of banana and mango. Its flowers are deep maroon and smell a little like rotting meat to attract the flies and beetles that pollinate them.

Pink Lady's Slipper

Cypripedium acaule

Vulnerable

Up close · photo: zhanna_galas (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: Beth Katz (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-SA)

This wild orchid's pink pouch traps bees that crawl in, so they have to squeeze out past the pollen to escape. It can't grow without a special fungus in the soil, so it never survives being dug up and moved.

Black-eyed Susan

Rudbeckia hirta

Doing well

Up close · photo: lasmoonshine (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Whole plant · photo: Emily (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

Each 'flower' is actually hundreds of tiny flowers packed into the dark center, surrounded by golden petals. Goldfinches love its seeds, and it's one of the first wildflowers to bloom in a field after a fire or plowing.

Eastern White Pine

Pinus strobus

Doing well

Up close · photo: Jason Michael Crockwell (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC-ND)

Whole plant · photo: Sequoia Sempervirens (iNaturalist, CC-BY-NC)

The tallest tree in eastern North America, white pine can grow over 150 feet, and its needles come in bundles of five. Its straight trunks were so prized for ship masts that the king of England once claimed every big one for his navy.